



A RIGHT SIDE UP STUDIO PUBLICATION •
PROVERBS 1, 3 • 1 KINGS 3

HUMBLE BEGINNINGS

*The first wisdom you'll ever need —
before it's wisdom about anything in
particular.*

BEGIN READING ↓

AN INVITATION

If you were offered anything, what would you ask for?

Not hypothetically. Imagine the offer was real — no budget, no catch, just: name it. Most of us have run that daydream. It's a fun game to play, right up until someone actually asks you to answer for real.

That's the exact position Solomon is in at the start of 1 Kings 3. Young. Unproven. Following a father whose reputation could crush anyone standing next to him. And in the middle of the night, God shows up and says it plainly: ask for whatever you want.

Whatever Solomon says next is going to tell everyone — and him — exactly who he is.

Real wisdom doesn't start with what you know. It starts with the reverence to admit what you don't, and the trust to ask the one who does.

The Bible has a word for this kind of wisdom: *hokmah* — skillful living, the difference between knowing a fact and knowing how to actually move through your life. Proverbs hands you the theory. The stories around it hand you the practice.

This is where the whole *Wisdom IRL* series has to start — not with a skill, but with the posture underneath every skill that follows.

01 **REVERENCE**

Proverbs 1:7

02 **HUMILITY**

Proverbs 3:5 · 1 Kings 3:7

03 **A LISTENING HEART**

Proverbs 3:6 · 1 Kings 3:9

01 REVERENCE

*What happens when you stand in front of
something too big to manage?*

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THE FOUNDATION

PROVERBS 1:7

Picture a call from someone who could give you anything. No budget. No catch. Just: *name it*. That's the position Solomon is in, at the very start of his reign.

In the middle of the night, God asks him plainly: “*Ask for whatever you want me to give you*” (1 Kings 3:5). Whatever Solomon says next will tell everyone — and him — exactly who he is.

The Hebrew word behind “fear” here is יִרָאָה — *yirah*. It isn't the word for being afraid of something that might hurt you. It's the word for what happens when you stand at the edge of something too vast to take in — a posture, not a terror.

Proverbs puts this word first on purpose. It calls it the foundation — everything the book later says about money, speech, work, and anger gets built on top of this one brick. Skip it, and the rest doesn't hold.

Notice where Solomon is standing when the offer comes — not on a throne yet, not with a temple built, not with a résumé. A young king at a worship site, sacrifices still in the air. Reverence was already in motion before the offer was ever made.

Wisdom doesn't start with information. It starts with awe.

PRACTICE

When have you stood in front of something — a person, a diagnosis, a canyon, a newborn — too big to manage? What did that do to you?

PRAYER

God who cannot be managed — meet me in what I can't take in, and let awe be the first thing I feel, not the last.

02 HUMILITY

*What do you do when you're the one who's
supposed to already know?*

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A KING WHO DIDN'T KNOW

PROVERBS 3:5 • 1 KINGS 3:7

Reverence toward God is only half the foundation. The other half is what you believe about yourself.

Ancient Near Eastern kings didn't talk like this. Royal inscriptions from the period boast of wisdom given to a king at birth — divine backing for a competence he was expected to already have. The king was the source of wisdom for his people, not a recipient of it.

Solomon breaks that script out loud, on the record, to God's face: *“I am only a little child and do not know how to carry out my duties”* (1 Kings 3:7). For a king, in that culture, this is close to unthinkable. The one moment he's supposed to project competence, he confesses the opposite.

Proverbs 3:5 asks exactly this of us: **“Trust in the Lord with all your heart; do not depend on your own understanding.”** Not *try harder to figure it out* — do not depend on your own understanding, at all. Most of the damage in our lives doesn't come from a lack of information. It comes from trusting our own read on a situation past the point that read can be trusted.

The competence you think you need to project is the exact thing wisdom asks you to put down.

PRACTICE

Name a decision where you were completely confident in your own read on things — and your confidence turned out to be the problem, not the missing piece.

PRAYER

Lord, I don't always know how to carry out my own duties. Take the competence I'm protecting and give me something truer to stand on.

A LISTENING HEART

What do you ask for once the myth of self-sufficiency is gone?

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LEV SHOMEA

PROVERBS 3:6 • 1 KINGS 3:9–13

So give your servant a discerning heart to govern your people and to distinguish between right and wrong (1 Kings 3:9). The Hebrew behind “discerning heart” is literally לֵב שֹׁמֵעַ — *lev shomea*, “a hearing heart.”

Not a mind that calculates faster. Not a memory that holds more. A heart built to keep hearing from someone else, on purpose, for the rest of its life.

That's the request that pleased God — not because it was clever, but because it was the one request that admitted it would need to be answered again. Solomon didn't ask to graduate from needing God. He asked for an organ built to keep listening.

“Seek his will in all you do, and he will show you which path to take” (Proverbs 3:6). And God's response is worth sitting in: because Solomon didn't ask for a long life, wealth, or the defeat of his enemies, he's given wisdom — and all of that besides, unasked.

Humility doesn't just avoid a trap. It opens a hand wide enough to receive more than the hand that was grabbing ever could.

The request that pleases God is the one that admits you'll need to keep asking.

PRACTICE

Where in your life right now would it cost you the most to say, out loud, “I don't actually know what I'm doing”? That's usually where a listening habit needs to start.

PRAYER

Give me a heart that listens, not a mind that's finished learning. I'd rather keep asking than stop needing you.

ISSUE ONE

Ask Before You Assume

Solomon asked for wisdom, and God gave him more than he asked. Not because the request was clever — because it was honest. He named exactly what he didn't have, and God met him there.

That's the pattern this whole series will keep returning to. Not confidence. Not competence. Reverence first — then a hand open enough to receive what you can't earn.

This week, notice what you're already chasing when no one's watching. Name the one place you've been trusting your own read instead of asking. Then build one small pause before the next hard decision — long enough to ask before you assume.

You already have a working answer to “what would you ask for.” It's visible in what you actually chase when no one's watching.

Wherever you're standing in front of something too big to manage this week — may reverence be your first response, not your last resort.

ASK BEFORE YOU ASSUME

This is Issue One of Wisdom IRL — eight field guides through Proverbs, for the wisdom underneath every skill that follows. Issue One preaches September 27.

FREE TO READ ONLINE • MADE TO PRINT AND PASS ALONG

**THE KINGDOM DOES NOT TURN THE WORLD
UPSIDE DOWN.**

**IT TURNS AN UPSIDE-DOWN WORLD RIGHT
SIDE UP.**

The Right Side Up

Jesus turns an already upside-down world right side up.